The Lake District Book Festival



Information for funding partners

CARTMEL RACECOURSE
Annually, 2nd weekend in June
Next festival 11th-13th June 2027
www.lakedistrictbookfestival.co.uk

The Lake District Book Festival comprises...



Every June, a long weekend of talks, interviews, panels and debates…

- …featuring a combination of exceptional local, national and international speakers – *'bringing the world to the Lakes & the Lakes to the world',*
- all talks & debates taking place in the tents and in the Grandstand building of Cartmel Racecourse, with an opening ceremony in the sublime 12th century Cartmel Priory;
- Food producers selling the best of home-grown, home-made (including vegan and organic) food from across the county;
- Festival Bookshop by Verey Books of Pooley Bridge.



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Why sponsor a book festival?

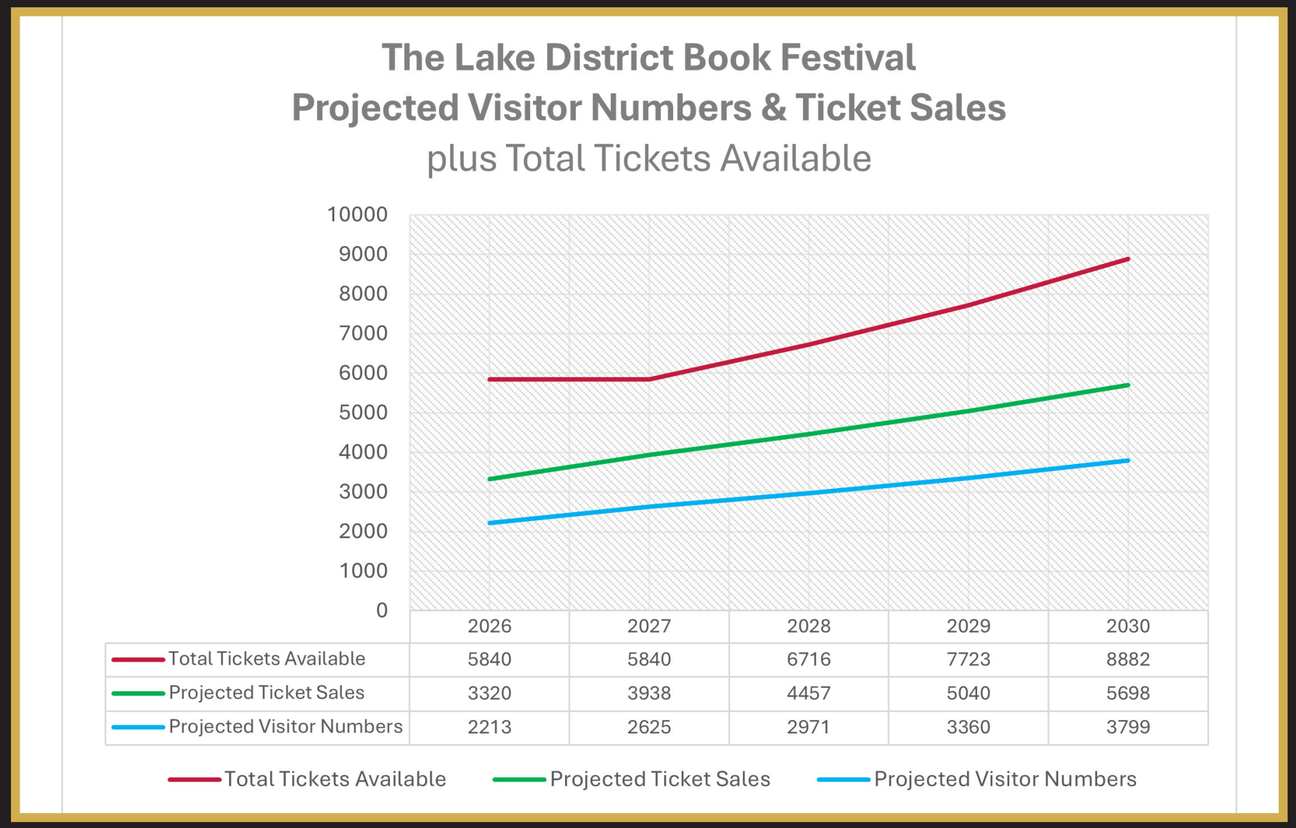
- Book festivals are an international phenomenon. They bring debate, the exploration of ideas in all sectors, challenge.
- Book festivals are analogue, not digital. Guests have the opportunity to listen to and question top writers and thinkers in person.
- A book festival audience is educated, curious, affluent. The economic benefits to an area hosting a book festival include a significant boost to tourism income. (June being a ‘shoulder period’, the timing of The Lake District Book Festival is of particular benefit to local hotel & accommodation owners.)
- An important adjunct of The Lake District Book Festival is the Schools Programme. As funding for the Festival consolidates, so too opportunities for the schools programme will grow. (see p8)
- To sponsor The Lake District Book Festival will be to celebrate and supplement the region’s rich literary tradition – whose leading lights vary from William Wordsworth & Arthur Ransome to Sarah Hall & James Rebanks.





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Five-year visitor number projections



	2026	2027	2028	2029	2030
Total Tickets Available	5840	5840	6716	7723	8882
Projected Ticket Sales	3320	3938	4457	5040	5698
Projected Visitor Numbers	2213	2625	2971	3360	3799



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Outline sponsorship opportunity I (2027)



CORPORATE OR PRIVATE GUEST ENTERTAINMENT - £900 per 15 guests

- Use of a private tent for a total of 15 guests for one day of the festival;
- Option to brand the tent;
- Up to 15 free talk tickets;
- Tickets to opening ceremony at Cartmel Priory at 20% discount;
- Further tickets to talks available at 20% discount;
- Acknowledgment on festival website and in festival newsletter.



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Outline sponsorship opportunity II (2027)



INDIVIDUAL TALK SPONSORSHIP - £2000 per talk

- Use of a private tent (with option to brand) for a total of 15 guests for one day of the festival;
- Acknowledgement in all references to sponsored event – on website, in newsletters & on social media;
- Opportunity to meet sponsored author/panelists;
- 2 x pairs of free tickets to opening ceremony in Cartmel Priory;
- 5 x pairs of free tickets to sponsored event; further tickets available to sponsored event or other talks at 20% discount;
- Priority parking.



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Outline sponsorship opportunity III (2027)



HOSPITALITY TENT SPONSORSHIP - £5000

- As branded sponsor of central hospitality tent - where all festival-goers will be able to convene, mingle, eat & drink - significant weekend-long presence on the Festival campus;
- Opportunity to host corporate guests within this tent;
- Opportunity to place sponsors' product before the entire Festival audience;
- Acknowledgement on website, in Festival newsletters, on social media;
- 5 x pairs of free tickets to opening ceremony in Cartmel Priory;
- 10 x pairs of free tickets (total) to chosen talks; further tickets available at 20% discount;
- Priority parking;
- Assistance with guest catering via Campbell & Rowley.

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Outline sponsorship opportunity IV (2027)

INDIVIDUAL VENUE SPONSORSHIP - from £5000 - £15,000

There are three talk venues on the racecourse - The Hampsfell Tent (capacity 350); Grandstand (capacity 150); The Humphrey Head Tent (capacity 150).

- Opportunity to be sole branded sponsor of a single talk venue over the weekend;
- Free tickets for corporate guests to talks within this talk venue;
- Opportunity to place sponsors' product on seats at each talk within this venue;
- Acknowledgement on website, in Festival newsletters, on social media;
- Free tickets to opening ceremony in Cartmel Priory;
- Further tickets available at 20% discount;
- Priority parking;
- Assistance with guest catering via Campbell & Rowley.



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Schools Programme
The next chapter...

An intrinsic part of the festival is the provision of a schools programme that will share the benefits of the festival with young writers, artists and opinion-formers of the future.

- In partnership with an initial four secondary schools (Cartmel CofE, Ulverston Victoria, Dallam School & St Bernard's, Barrow), the Festival offers twice-yearly visits from leading writers.

- The undertaking is to send not YA or children's authors but grown-up authors of national reputation who will talk about their lives, their practice, their inspirations. The aim is to transport 14-18 year old students beyond the confines of the school walls and give them a sense of the tremendous possibility of the written and spoken word – and its critical importance to a functioning society.

- An important corollary of this programme is the Festival Volunteers scheme, in which those same students are invited to take part in the delivery of the Festival itself, further endorsing the message that the arts and the humanities bring eye-opening, horizon-changing opportunities. In 2026, this scheme involved 98 student volunteers and was extremely popular with and well received by schools, students & parents alike.





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The case for Cartmel

- Approximately 18 million walkers and holidaymakers visit the Lake District every year – around 200,000 of these visit Cartmel.

- The Festival audience comes not just from Cumbria & the Lakes but from the university city of Lancaster, the Unesco City of Literature Manchester and from across Lancashire, Greater Manchester and Yorkshire. Cartmel has excellent transport links.

- Cartmel occupies a stunning location beneath Cartmel Fell, close to the mouth of the Morecambe Estuary. '*A thimble full of diamonds',* it is home to the heartbreakingly beautiful Cartmel Priory and is known as a gastronomic destination thanks to its range of pubs, cafés, artisanal food shops & to Simon Rogan's Michelin 3* restaurant, L'Enclume.

- The area is fully geared for visitors – there are scores of B&Bs, pubs, holiday lets, hotels and other rentable accommodation.

- Cartmel Racecourse has an extensive permanent infrastructure while its management has long experience in managing large influxes of visitors.



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Founded, organised and hosted by...



Christopher de Bellaigue is an award-winning author and journalist. His work has appeared in some of the world's most trusted media outlets including *The Guardian* & *The New York Review of Books*. Thanks to his experience on the international stage, Christopher has forged excellent relationships with top writers & speakers.



Charlotte Fairbairn is the former head of content at Lowther Castle near Penrith. Under Charlotte's watch, Lowther Castle has become one of the most talked about visitor attractions in the northwest. Charlotte is a freelance creative consultant and the author of four novels.



Cartmel Racecourse is run by The Holker Group – owned by the Cavendish family. The Cavendishes have lived at nearby Holker Hall since the mid-18th century. The racecourse is one of the most popular jump-racing venues in the UK.



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